nineteen and who eventually led the LTTE to become the deadliest guerilla force in the world, with experts calling it more fearsome than the militia of the Colombian drug lord Pablo Escobar. The LTTE's 10,000-plus members swore by Prabhakaran and were ready to bite cyanide than be taken into custody. Such was his charisma.

Born in a fisherman's family on 26 November 1954 in Valvettithurai, Jaffna, Prabhakaran was known as an introvert who preferred spending most of his time buried in books in junior school. By the time he reached senior high, he was drawn to Tamil movements. Right from an early age, Prabhakaran refused to accept the discriminatory treatment meted out to Tamils by the Sinhalese in Sri Lanka. Claiming to be an admirer of Subhas Chandra Bose and Bhagat Singh, he disagreed with his seniors in the Tamil movement and made it clear that an armed struggle was the only way to win freedom and not through dialogue, which had failed to produce any results for the Tamils in northern Sri Lanka.

Soon after Rajiv Gandhi's assassination, the *India Today* magazine wrote about how Prabhakaran picked his recruits young, predominantly in the age group of twelve to thirteen. These children were already aware of the hardship and the atrocities inflicted by Sri Lankan soldiers. Training would be completed by an oath of personal loyalty to Prabhakaran and the gift of a cyanide capsule to the new guerrilla on his behalf. In the quest for supremacy, which began nearly eight years ago, Prabhakaran's men devoured the frontline leadership of all the other major Tamil guerrilla groups to emerge as the unchallenged rulers in Jaffna. His funds came from drug smuggling, havala rackets, extortions and donations from expatriate Tamils. Investigations conducted by Interpol had revealed that 80 per cent of the Sri Lankan nationals sent to jail abroad for drug trafficking were reported to be Tamils. *The Washington Post* and Bogota's Spanish paper *El Tiempo* first busted the Tigers' links with Colombia's notorious Medellin Cartel.[7]

The BBC, in its obituary of Prabhakaran, wrote that the rebel leader lived in secrecy all his life. Despite becoming known to the world, he rarely appeared in public. It said,